

***The Sims 4* Needs Your Money: The Kotaku Review**

Why *The Sims 4* was once great but effectively destroyed their new player interest and long-standing community with greed



When I was younger, I used to constantly beg my parents for the newest and greatest *Sims 4* DLC pack, so much so, it became a regular negotiation ritual within my house. Is the pack on sale? No? I can wait for the price to drop. How much storage will it take up on my mom's computer? Well, if I move the photos folder to a flashdrive, it'll free up space. You don't need those photos anyways, right, Mom? It's Christmas, and Dad said I could get two packs since they're both half off!

I loved, and still do love, bittersweetly, *The Sims 4*. Coming home from school, when I would reenter my week long *Sims* binge before discarding the game for another month, I could hardly wait to crack open my mom's laptop and see what my sims were up to. The appeal wasn't just in the ability to control my sims and throw them in a plethora of absurd situations (though, that was always a perk). It also lied in the connection little-ol' me had with the sims I spent years watching grow up, go to school, fall in love, get a job, and eventually die. The writer within me was captivated with the endless possibilities for story. I simply couldn't put the game down.

And, I wasn't the only one. Across the years, all the way from the very first *Sims* game, *The Sims* has garnered a large and extremely loyal following. Whether a player is solely interested in character design (Create-A-Sim), building (Build Mode), or gameplay (Live Mode), *The Sims* has something to offer for everyone. Because of this aspect, it has dominated the life simulator market in both popularity and sales. For a time, it seemed that nothing would beat the notoriety *The Sims* franchise had achieved in their 14 years of existence.

That was until 2019 came around and players began to notice a change in quality within *The Sims 4*. Some community members mark the beginning of the end as far back as the game's release in 2014, but large-scale recognition didn't really take form until 2019 when the Discover University DLC expansion pack came out. The Discover University expansion pack was a highly anticipated DLC among simmers (the nerdy term for sims players) as it introduced the "college experience" to the game. However, upon its release, simmers noticed the DLC was significantly lacking content, incredibly buggy, and felt unfinished.

While simmers complained endlessly about the lackluster pack, EA never did much about it. Instead, they kept pumping out DLCs over the next few years, all of which received similar reviews from simmers about missing content and broken mechanics. A notably disliked addition to the game was the introduction of kits: \$5.99 DLCs which only carried a handful of either Create-A-Sim or Build Mode items. These were especially hated by simmers because they felt like quick cash grabs, putting content behind unnecessary paywalls for a game that already felt hollow.

Right after the release of kits, in 2022, EA made the base game *Sims 4* free to play. While this sounds like a step in the right direction, away from allegations of materialism, it really just opened the door for EA to continue forefronting finances for the future of *Sims*. A lot of simmers, including myself, viewed this move as a scapegoat to boost the reputation of *The Sims*. There was already less and less new player interest in *The Sims 4* since the game had been out for some time at that point, so listing the game as free wasn't exactly going to lose EA any money—no one was buying the \$40 base game anyways! By making the game free, EA can feign generosity while planning to monetize other aspects of the game on the backend.

More recent money-centric features include in-game advertisements for DLCs, the incorporation of "maker packs"—DLC packs designed by well known simmers, and a new currency called "Moola" which allows players to buy packs from the in-game direct purchase store. Of course, nobody asked for these things. Simmers have instead been

asking developers to fix the game as it's been broken for numerous years with the release of all these DLCs and additions. Of course, these pleas have yet to be answered.

As if matters couldn't get worse, EA was recently bought out by the Saudi Arabia Public Investment Fund for \$55 Billion. This caused mass panic within the *Sims* community for where the game might be headed and how playing the game now is subsequently a political move—playing the game supports Saudi Arabia. On top of all the preexisting accusations EA has faced from the *Sims* community regarding the exploitation of players, this news is no saving grace.

What does all of this mean for *The Sims 4*? For the future of the franchise? For the game itself?

For the franchise, it's hard to deny this isn't the downfall. At one point, EA had announced "Project Rene" which was meant to be the beginnings of *The Sims 5*. However, EA effectively canceled the project and announced there would be no *Sims 5* to come. This means that *The Sims 4* will be the last game in the series. And, with the reputation it already has, I can't imagine a world where EA can redeem themselves and restore *The Sims* to its original glory.

As for the game itself, all of these pieces of information make it difficult to view the game as I once did when I was a child. When I play *The Sims 4* today, the game feels unfamiliar. The start page has been redesigned and optimized for maximum advertising room. The new worlds I've bought from DLCs have less space to build on and more filler environments inaccessible due to invisible barriers. The sims themselves take in-game hours to do literally anything, pausing for no apparent reason at every queued command.

While I would love to say that *The Sims 4* has just hit a rough patch and will come back from this, I personally don't think I'll ever be able to view the game the same having experienced all the turmoil surrounding it. I'm not the only one either. Simmers across the community have expressed similar tastes of disdain for the game they once cherished. Now, simmers express nostalgia for times when the whole *Sims* franchise was just a silly game and not a pickpocket.

Knowing what I do, and seeing how *The Sims 4* has devolved from its release, it's clear that *The Sims 4* was never meant to one-up its predecessors in quality. *The Sims 4* was designed for the purpose of cashing a check. EA knew the community, having loved all the previous games, would be unable to resist the shiny new toy that was *The Sims 4*. And, down the line, when the community was hooked, EA could start digging through wallets without

even looking. Because, really, it didn't matter what *The Sims 4* ran like—people could complain and complain, but they'd never actually stop playing.

The Sims 4 then became a cash cow for EA to milk every last drop out of. We, as simmers, are standing around with a bucket of hay. When that bucket is empty, and the cow dies, EA will close the pasture doors and retire the farm for good.